

PTI

Kamareddy, a busy poultry hub 117 km from Hyderabad and the district headquarters, is a sea of pink on November 9. Five-storey-tall cutouts of the Telangana chief minister, K. Chandrashekar Rao, better known by his acronym KCR, line the streets. As also the party symbol—a car in the shape of the erstwhile Ambassador of Hindustan Motors. Everything is in bright pink, the colour of the party rechristened the Bharat Rashtra Samithi last year, to burnish its national credentials. Pink symbolises universal peace and love, and also evokes comfort, compassion and warmth—reasons KCR chose that colour for BRS.

Even the band at the venue of the public meeting is dressed in shades of pink. It is belting out party songs in praise of KCR, most of which end with a rousing call of "*Jai, Jai, Telangana*". Another popular rhyme goes—"*Ek Do Teen Baar, Desh Ka Neta KCR*" (Once, twice, third time, the leader of the nation is KCR). It well captures the aspirations of a man who first led the agitation for the state and since 2014 has been guiding its destiny. Now, he is seeking a third successive term as chief minister when Telangana goes to the polls on November 30.

In an unusual move, the 69-year-old KCR chose Kamareddy as an additional seat to contest from. He has represented the Gajwel constituency in neighbouring Siddipet district in the 2014 and 2018 assembly elections. The Opposition sees it as a sign of KCR's insecurity. Opinion polls, too, are reflecting anti-incumbency against him, which may see his party secure far less seats than the 88 out of 119 seats it won in 2018.

KCR, though, betrays no sign of insecurity. "KCR is never worried. There is pro-incumbency," he told INDIA TODAY (*see interview*). He believes his party is still in the pink of health and will romp home with a comfortable majority. "My party's tally this time will be higher than ever before—95-100 seats. I have my own reasons for contesting two seats, which I'll reveal after the results." Speculation is he may be preparing Kamareddy as a base to contest the 2024 Lok Sabha election. If his party wins the state polls handsomely, KCR may well push the pedal on his national ambitions—he hinted as much in his interview—though he made it clear it will not be at the cost of the state.

THE BRS GAMEPLAN

Right now, KCR is leaving nothing to chance. He had announced BRS candidates for 115 of the 119 assembly segments in August itself, much earlier than his main rivals, the Indian National Congress and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) did; they came out with their list of candidates only weeks before the nominations closed. Though surveys predicted an uphill task for many BRS MLAs to get re-elected, KCR did not drop them. Instead, he gave tickets to all his ministers and senior MLAs, making changes only in seven constituencies. The Opposition saw it as another sign of KCR's weakness—the fear of rebellion within the ranks if he did not re-nominate the MLAs. On his part, KCR says these MLAs had fought by his side in the battle for Telangana's statehood and that since there was a wave in his favour, he did not see any reason to replace them.

What the early announcement of candidates did help BRS do was to be the first off the block in the election campaign, leaving the Congress and BJP scrambling. With KCR himself at the